

Twelve questions to ask yourself before a psychedelic journey

If pilots can run a checklist, so can we. Mid-flight whoopsies can be tricky to handle.

Preparation is more than set and setting. In the four weeks before a journey, we can slow down, tune in and reflect.

The twelve conditions come from Alfried Längle's Existential Analysis. His claim is that a person needs four things to be able to say yes to their own existence, and that each of the four has three conditions underneath it. Twelve in all. They are not a personality test and there is no score at the end. They are the questions the checklist asks.

Can I be?	FM1 · GROUNDED	Support · Space · Protection
Do I like being?	FM2 · RELATIONSHIPS	Time · Closeness · Relating
Am I allowed to be me?	FM3 · OFFER	Attention · Appreciation · Justice
For what should I live?	FM4 · WHOLENESS	Greater Context · Field of Activity · Future Value

Read down the middle column and it spells GROW: Grounded, Relationships, Offer, Wholeness. That is the preparation protocol these questions were built for.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

- Not a test, and not a score. Nothing here adds up to a number.
- Not a diagnosis. It describes what you can say today, not what is true of you.
- Not a clearance to proceed, and not medical advice. No checklist can give you that.
- Not a substitute for a therapist, a doctor, or a person who knows you.

How to use it

Four weeks, one Fundamental Motivation a week, in order. They build on one another: the second assumes the first, and the fourth assumes all three. It is worth keeping them in sequence.

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|--------------------|---|
| 1. TUNE IN | Listen to the meditation for that Fundamental Motivation. Nothing to answer yet. |
| 2. SIT | Two or three minutes afterwards with nothing happening. This is part of it. |
| 3. REFLECT | Three questions, one per prerequisite. Write by hand if you can. |
| 4. LEAVE IT | Come back to the page later in the week and add what surfaced. The first answer is rarely the whole answer. |

Please listen to the meditation before you look at the questions. It is there to put you in contact with what the questions are about, so that the answers come from somewhere a little deeper than what you already think about yourself. Each meditation folds in the ones before it, and they get longer: fifteen minutes at the first, forty-five at the last. That lengthening is deliberate. It is gentle practice for holding your attention inwards for the kind of stretch a journey will ask of you.

IF A QUESTION COMES UP EMPTY

Some of these questions may come up empty, and that is worth as much as a full page. Perhaps more. An empty line is telling you something, and it does not require you to do anything about it today. You can just sit with it for now. And if several come up empty at once, or if what surfaces is more than you want to hold on your own, I encourage you to take it to someone before you take it into a journey: a therapist, a doctor, or a person who knows you well.

Two honest questions

What if I do not have four weeks?

Then do them in whatever time you have, still in order, even if that is four evenings. The order carries the argument; the calendar does not. But notice that wanting to compress the preparation is itself worth a line on the page.

What if I am not planning a journey at all?

The twelve conditions are not about psychedelics. They are Längle's account of what a person needs in order to say yes to their own life, and they were being asked in consulting rooms for decades before anyone pointed them at this. Use them anyway.



The four meditations

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research.aestra.ca/ea-meditations

Can I be?

The ground floor. Whether the world holds you, or whether you are holding yourself up.

“Can I be... here... now?”

1

Protection

Somewhere you are not braced. Not the absence of danger, but a place you can rest.

Where in your life do you feel safe enough to put your guard down? And where does the ground feel least solid under you?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Do I enjoy protection, acceptance, do I feel at home somewhere?

2

Space

Room to exist without justifying it. Physical room, and the other kind.

Where do you have room simply to be, without having to earn it or explain it? Where do you feel pressed in?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Do I have enough space for being there?

3

Support

What holds when you stop holding yourself up. A chair, a person, a routine, the floor.

When things give way, what holds? Who or what can you actually lean your weight on?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Where do I find support in my life?

When it is missing: restlessness, insecurity and fear.

Do I like being?

Not whether life is going well. Whether you are in touch with it, and whether anything still reaches you here... now?"

4

Relationship

What you are still in touch with. What moves you, and what you move towards.

What are you drawn towards at the moment? What still reaches you?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Do I have relationships, in which I feel closeness, for which I spend time and in which I experience community?

5

Time

To give something your time is to give away a part of your life. Worth checking where yours goes.

Where does your time actually go, and how much of it goes to what matters to you?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

What do I take time for? To take time for something means to give away a part of one's life.

6

Closeness

Being near something, and letting it land. Including plants, animals and places, not only people.

Who are you close to? And what happens in you when someone comes near?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Can I feel close and maintain closeness to things, plants, animals and people? Can I admit the closeness of someone else?

When it is missing: longing, then coldness, and finally depression.

Am I allowed to be me?

Whether you have the right to be who you actually are, in front of other people, ~~without editing or masking~~... now?"

7

Attention

Being seen, and looking. It runs both ways, and the inward direction is the one people skip.

What do you turn your attention towards? What in your own inner life still interests you?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

By whom am I seen? Who considers my uniqueness and respects my boundaries?

8

Justice

Being dealt with fairly. Knowing, without arguing yourself out of it, when you were not.

Where have you been dealt with fairly, and where have you not? What does that still ask of you?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Do people do me justice?

9

Appreciation

Worth that does not have to be earned again every morning. Other people's, and your own.

What do you value in yourself? What would you want another person to see in you?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

For what am I appreciated: for what can I appreciate myself? The sum of these experiences builds the self-esteem.

When it is missing: solitude, and losing hold of who you are.

For what should I live?

What your life is for. Not in the abstract, but the thing that is actually asking to be done. “Is this... a purposeful... life?”

10

Field of Activity

Somewhere you are needed and can actually do something. Room to act, not only to be.

Where do you have room to act? What feels open to you?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Is there a place where I feel needed, where I can be productive?

11

Structural Context

The larger thing you are part of, which gives the rest of it direction. A family, a field, a faith, a forest.

What are you a part of? Where do you feel needed?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Do I see and experience myself in a larger context that provides structure and orientation to my life? Where I want to be integrated?

12

Value to be Realized

What still wants to happen in your life. Potential that has not yet been realized.

What is asking to be lived out through you? And what would you want this experience to serve?

LÄNGLE ASKS IT THIS WAY

Is there anything that should still be realized in my life?

When it is missing: emptiness, frustration, even despair.

When you have all four pages

When the four weeks are done, I invite you to lay the pages out together, in order, and give yourself a few moments with them.

There is nothing here to add up. No total, no score. Perhaps just noticing which of the twelve had something to say right away, which ones took the whole week to arrive, and which ones are still empty.

The empty ones are worth staying with. You are welcome to leave them just as they are for now, and to come back to them when it feels appropriate.

Where this comes from

The Four Fundamental Motivations and the twelve conditions are Alfried Längle's, developed within Existential Analysis out of Viktor Frankl's logotherapy. The small italic question under each one is his own, quoted from his 2002 and 2011 papers. The question you answered is adapted from the Test of Existential Motivations, opened out so it can be answered rather than rated.

The meditations and the four-week shape are from the GROW preparation protocol, a master's thesis in Existential Analysis on preparation for psychedelic-assisted therapy.

And none of it would be here without the knowledge keepers who carried these medicines: María Sabina Magdalena García and the Mazatec people of Huautla de Jiménez above all, whose knowledge reached the West at a cost to her that she did not consent to and did not recover from. This sheet is an attempt at the other thing: preparation, consent, and going slowly.

The four meditations, permanently

FM1 "Can I be... here... now?"

FM2 "Do I like being... here... now?"

FM3 "Am I allowed to be myself... here... now?"

FM4 "Is this... a purposeful... life?"

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The four meditations
research.aestra.ca/ea-meditations



This worksheet
research.aestra.ca/ea-preflight

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